
Enabling the Frontier

Structural Outline — All 32 Principles

Eric Forbes | Working Draft | August 8, 2026

Section I Building the Team (8 Principles)

- I.1. Cultivate Broad Capability First** — Build team depth before optimizing for output.
- I.2. Remove the Layers** — Eliminate every bureaucratic layer that slows frontier work.
- I.3. Altitude of Decomposition** — Use decomposition level as a framework for seniority and growth.
- I.4. Stakeholder Registry** — Design stakeholder communication as architecture, not a contact list.
- I.5. Project vs. Operations Clarity** — Know which mode you are in. They require different leadership.
- I.6. The Junkyard Principle** — *[Thesis to be developed with Eric.]*
- I.7. [Principle 7]** — *[Title and thesis to be confirmed.]*
- I.8. [Principle 8]** — *[Title and thesis to be confirmed.]*

Section II Leading the Team (9 Principles)

- II.1. Demo Discipline** — Demo what you have, on cadence. Positive discipline, not punishment.
- II.2. Servant Leadership** — The leader's job is to serve the team's ability to do the work.
- II.3. Maintain Fundamentals Under Pressure** — Good habits erode first under stress. Defend them hardest then.
- II.4. The Power of Saying No** — Protecting team focus is a leadership act.
- II.5. Communication Infrastructure** — Design your information flows deliberately.
- II.6. Psychological Safety** — Teams that can fail safely learn faster.
- II.7. Humble / Parenting-Style Leadership** — *[Framing TBD—standalone principle or*

emotional underpinning of servant leadership (parenting analogy)? Resolve with Eric.]

II.8. Earn Your Real Estate — Internal promotion is a leadership responsibility, not an HR function.

II.9. Information Gatekeeping Is Toxicity — Hoarding information is invisible hierarchy. It destroys trust. *(Story banked — Section II confirmed, parent principle TBD.)*

Section III Perspective & Framing (10 Principles)

III.1. Engineers as Self-Managing — When engineers understand the full trade space, they self-direct effectively.

III.2. Vision Sourcing vs. Vision Sinking — Leaders source vision upward. They do not sink it.

III.3. Radical Optimism — Optimism is a discipline, not a mood.

III.4. Protect the Passion — Guard what drives people. Passion is the engine of frontier work.

III.5. Program Management from Day One — Time, cost, scope, and manufacturability are dimensions from day one.

III.6. Feedback Is the Multiplier — The quantity of feedback loops is a primary driver of outcomes.

III.7. The Fulcrum Principle — Physical proximity to your team is a leadership act.

III.8. Super-Optimism: Protect the Magic — *[May merge with Radical Optimism—resolve with Eric.]*

III.9. The Permission Layer — Control disguised as coordination creates an invisible bottleneck. It looks like order from outside, making it immune to intervention. *(Story attached: The Orderly Bottleneck.)*

III.10. [Principle 10] — *[Title and thesis to be confirmed.]*

Section IV Recognition & Belief (2 Principles) ! UNDERDEVELOPED

IV.1. Specific Earned Affirmation — Specific, earned affirmation is load-bearing fuel. Generic praise is noise.

IV.2. [Principle 2] — *[Title and thesis to be confirmed. Section needs development.]*

Section V Knowledge & Continuity (3 Principles)

- V.1. Apply Academic Research Rigor** — Research-grade documentation discipline is a competitive advantage.
- V.2. Stand on Each Other’s Shoulders** — Each generation of the team should start from a higher floor than the last. (*Story attached: Red Program Tracing.*)
- V.3. [*Principle 3*]** — [*Title and thesis to be confirmed.*]

Story Bank — Banked, not yet placed: too many architects · conflict via depersonalization · servant leader steps back · workflow design / pivot-persist · delegation without creative ownership · information gatekeeping · absorbing pressure vs. exposing it · “next level” means steadier (coaching story)

Principle candidates — raw concepts, unplaced: engineers own the product upward, and are responsible for the uncertainty — answer capability questions clearly and confidently, then own the “it depends” underneath (neighbors: III.1, absorbing-pressure story, I.3, “next level” coaching story; possibly fills an open TBD slot)

Confirmed placements: Red Program Tracing → V.2 Stand on Each Other’s Shoulders · The Orderly Bottleneck → III.9 The Permission Layer

Open structural questions: (1) Helmier Catechism—formal framework or Eric’s adaptation? Spelling unverified. (2) Apollo decomposition + time-as-currency—one principle or two? (3) Parenting analogy—standalone or emotional underpinning of servant leadership? (4) Absorbing pressure vs. exposing it—new Section II principle, or supporting angle for II.3 Maintain Fundamentals Under Pressure / III.1 Engineers as Self-Managing? (5) “Vision First”—referenced in Section I (Remove the Layers) as the book’s philosophical foundation, but no principle carries that title. Closest existing principles: III.1 Engineers as Self-Managing, III.2 Vision Sourcing. Resolve where it lives—possibly a candidate for an open TBD slot. (6) Two logged external prompts directly contradict banked material and need Eric’s resolution: “promotion trap” (make yourself replaceable) vs. V.2 Stand on Each Other’s Shoulders (build systems that outlast you) may be the same idea from two angles; “promotions go to the visible” vs. the “next level means steadier” story are closer to a real contradiction. See CLAUDE.md §External Prompts for full detail—not reproduced here since these are not yet Eric’s own material.